Airlines flight from Karachi's Drigh Road aerodrome and landed in Bombay's Juhu airstrip, carrying 25 kg of four-anna airmail letters.

Weeks before his planned trip in 1982, JRD was discovered to have a heart problem. But that did not stop him. Such was his spirit and determination at the age of seventy-eight that his doctors were afraid to dissuade him, in case the disappointment would 'bring on a heart attack'. Against all advice and odds, he commemorated the golden jubilee of the flight by piloting a forty-eight-year-old de Havilland Leopard Moth monoplane and landing in Bombay once again.

For such a determined man and health enthusiast, surrendering the reins of the Tata empire was not a thought that could have occurred unless he was reminded of it by the inevitable signs of nature weakening his body. Until then, there was no urgency for him to announce his successor and he kept everyone guessing. Ratan himself was not hopeful of ending up as the final choice, as he would reveal later in an interview: 'Within [the] Tatas, nobody was sure that I would be the successor. And while JRD would say things like "one day you will have to look after the group", he never actually made a firm commitment to me.'

Last Man Standing

Though no one could be sure, by the beginning of 1989 it became increasingly evident that JRD was veering towards appointing Ratan as his successor. But he had not yet put Ratan in charge of any of the large group companies. Ratan did become chairman, TELCO, in December 1988, but this was not by JRD's design. The appointment came at the end of a high-octane drama with Sumant Moolgaokar playing the role of kingmaker.

Towards the end of the 1980s Moolgaokar had started keeping indifferent health. By 1988, he was only sparingly attending office. The senior management had to meet the ailing chairman at his residence once or twice a week to brief him. Moolgaokar was already eighty-two. Sensing that he would have to step down sooner than later, Russi Mody pushed himself to take over from the ailing veteran, claiming that JRD had chosen him as Moolgaokar's successor.

He made this claim after he resigned from TISCO's board in 1993. He told *Sunday* magazine that JRD had promised him that he would replace Moolgaokar. A decision was taken in JRD's room, where he was told to